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SEEKING HIS PRESENCE CM-to-be at this point, Majhi called on his predecessor Naveen Patnaik at his house to invite him for his oath-taking, Jun. 12

ODISHA

BJP's Tribal Trump Card

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

The BJP got a majority in Odisha "because of the blessings of its 45 million people desiring change. They reposed faith in the BJP, and we resolve to make Odisha number one". Mohan Charan Majhi, the party's first and the state's third tribal chief minister, will need to accomplish much to be able to live up to this promise. For, Odisha's electorate is high on expectation after bringing the curtain down on the fairly transformative 24-year reign of five-time CM Naveen Patnaik and his Biju Janata Dal (BJD).

The state's youngest CM ever, at 52, the fourth-term MLA from Keonjhar will have two deputies to share the load: Kanak Vardhan Singh Deo, 62, and Pravati Parida, 57. A repeat of the BJP's governance formula at work in Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh, it will also bring into play a complex grid of consultation, devolution and oversight, with multiple stakeholders. Quite unlike Patnaik's rule, therefore, his won't be a one-man show.

There's also the burden

MAJHI WILL HAVE TO BEAR THE BURDEN OF EXPECTATIONS FROM THE BJP, WITH NINE DEBUTANT MINISTERS AND A THREE-TIERED TOP

of inexperience—nine of the 16 ministers sworn in at the June 12 ceremony in Bhubaneswar, which had top-of-the-line BJP leaders led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi as well as the septuagenarian Patnaik in attendance, are debutant MLAs. Singh Deo alone has ministerial experience.

With 78 MLAs in the 147-member legislative assembly, the BJP has a thin majority, but believes Majhi's humble background will make him and the government widely acceptable. Majhi began his political career at the panchayat level, working his way to the top. He first became a member of the Kendujhar Sadar block in 1992 and then sarpanch of the Raikala panchayat in 1997.

Before joining politics, Majhi taught at the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh-affiliated Saraswati Shishu Mandir in Jhumpura in Kendujhar district, gradually building strong connections with the BJP's ideological parent. The son of a village school peon holds a bachelor's degree in law from the Dhenkanal Law College.